Parallel CNN Primitives with OpenMP: Padding, Convolution and Pooling

MTCS-103P — High Performance Computing Laboratory · Mini Project P1: Image Processing (2), Part 1

Submitted by: B. Sai Buvann — Registration no. 26010303001
Institution: Sri Sathya Sai Institute of Higher Learning
Implementation: C99 + OpenMP, written from scratch
Repository: https://github.com/buvann-11/Parallel-Image-Processing-OpenMP

1. Objective

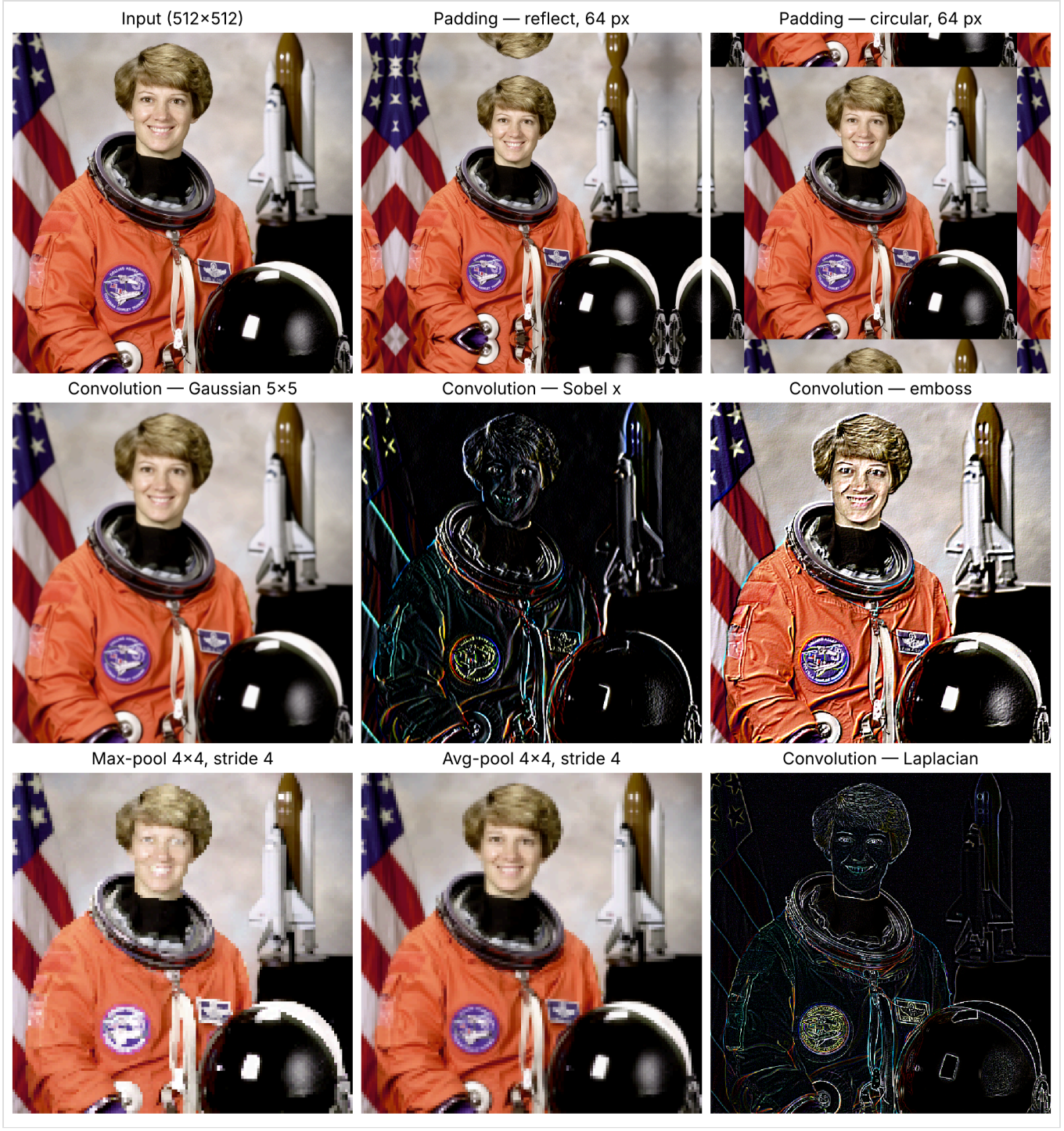
Convolutional neural networks spend almost all their time in three operations: **padding** the borders of a feature map, **convolving** it with learned filters, and **pooling** it down to a smaller map. All three are data-parallel — the same arithmetic applied independently to millions of values — which makes them natural candidates for shared-memory parallelism.

This work implements the three operations in C, parallelises each with OpenMP, proves that the parallel versions compute exactly what the serial versions compute, and measures and explains how well each one scales.

2. Results at a glance

Kernel	Serial (ms)	2 threads (ms)	Speedup
Convolution 3×3	27.95	14.03	1.99×
Convolution 5×5	75.51	35.67	2.12×
CNN convolution, 16 channels	90.38	46.35	1.95×
Max pooling 2×2	3.57	1.53	2.33×
Padding, reflect	2.10	0.61	3.42×

All outputs are bit-identical to the serial versions at every thread count, and identical to an independent NumPy implementation.



3. Algorithms

3.1 Padding

Four border modes, all computed by mapping each padded coordinate `i` back to a source index on an axis of length `n`:

Mode	Source index	Typical use
zeros	— (constant 0)	default CNN padding
replicate	`clip(i, 0, n−1)`	image borders
circular	`i mod n`	periodic signals
reflect	`m = i mod (2n−2)`, then `m` or `2n−2−m`	smooth borders

Using modular folding instead of a single reflection means pads **wider than the axis itself** work correctly — a case `numpy.pad` rejects for `reflect`.

3.2 Convolution

```
y[n,f,p,q] = bias[f] + Σc Σi Σj  w[f,c,i,j] · x[n, c, p·s + i·d, q·s + j·d]
```

Batched, multi-channel (N×C×H×W), with stride `s`, dilation `d` and bias. A **direct loop nest** is used rather than `im2col` + matrix multiply, so the parallelism measured is ours and not a BLAS library's. The loop order puts the **output column innermost** with the weight held in a register: at stride 1 the input access is unit-stride and the compiler vectorises it into fused multiply-adds. The input is padded once up front so the inner loops need no bounds checks. The same engine provides depthwise image filters: box, Gaussian 5×5, Sobel x/y, Laplacian, sharpen and emboss.

3.3 Pooling

Max and average pooling with any window, stride and padding, plus global average pooling. Instead of building a padded copy, each window is **clamped** to the real input, which has three benefits:

- max pooling never returns a padding value (feature maps contain negative numbers, so a zero pad could wrongly win the maximum);
- average pooling divides by the number of real elements, so border outputs are unbiased;
- no padded buffer is allocated — a full pass over memory saved on a kernel that is already memory-bound.

4. Parallelisation

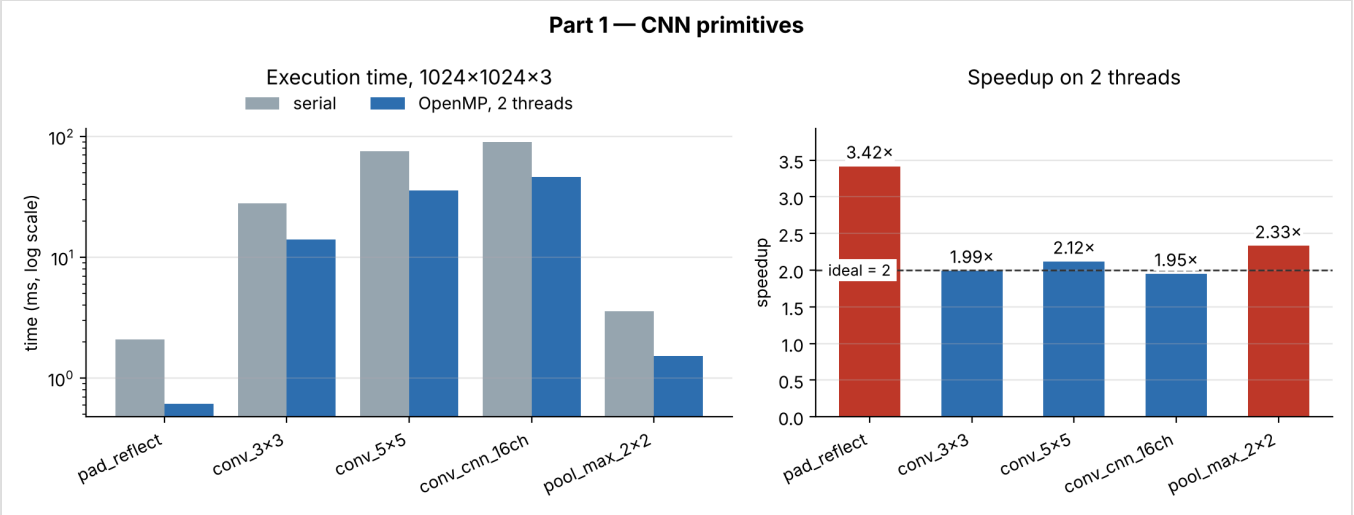
Every kernel exists twice: `<name>_serial()` with no OpenMP at all, and `<name>_omp()`. Speedup is always measured against the directive-free version — timing the parallel code on one thread would hide the OpenMP runtime's own cost.

```
#pragma omp parallel for collapse(3) schedule(runtime) default(none) ...
for (n = 0; n < N; ++n)              /* batch                     */
  for (c = 0; c < C; ++c)            /* channel                   */
    for (oy = 0; oy < out_h; ++oy)   /* output row: one owner     */
```

- **Row ownership.** Each iteration writes exactly one output row and nothing else, so no two threads ever write the same element: no atomics, no critical sections and no locks anywhere on a hot path.
- **`collapse(3)`.** A single one-channel image has `N = C = 1`; collapsing the three loops still gives every thread a share of the rows.
- **No false sharing by design.** All buffers are 64-byte aligned, so a row boundary never splits a cache line between two threads.
- **`schedule(runtime)`** lets the schedule be changed without recompiling, for the scheduling experiments.

5. Performance

Strong scaling on a 1024×1024×3 input, best of repeated runs after a warm-up, 2-core x86-64 Linux machine, GCC `-O3`.



Convolution scales ideally (1.95–2.12× on 2 cores). It is compute-bound: each output needs `k·k·C` multiply-adds, so the cores, not memory, are the limit — these kernels will keep scaling on more cores.

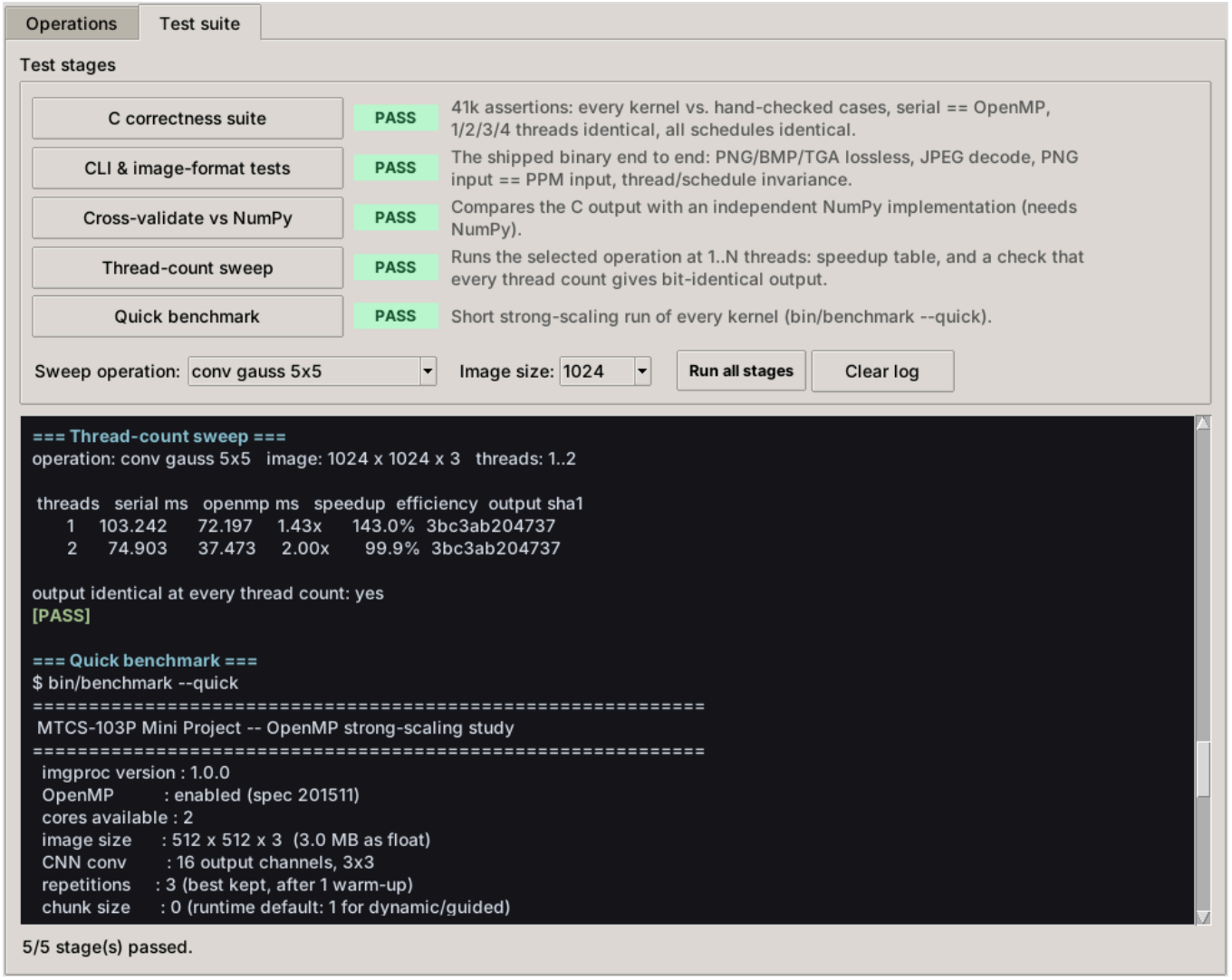
Padding and pooling appear superlinear (3.42× and 2.33×, red). They do almost no arithmetic and finish in 2–4 ms, so allocating and first-touching the 12 MB output buffer is a large share of the measured time — and that page work parallelises too. It is a property of the measurement, not the algorithm; timing the arithmetic alone would show them memory-bound, below 2×.

Loop schedule. Because one iteration is a whole output row, these kernels are insensitive to `dynamic` with chunk 1 (2.07× vs 2.16× for convolution 5×5). A very large chunk (8192) is harmful instead: a 1024-row image has only ~1000 iterations, so one thread gets all the work (1.07×). For uniform rows `static` is the right choice.

6. Correctness

Check	Result
OpenMP output = serial output	exact for padding, convolution and max/average pooling
Output at 1, 2, 3 and 4 threads; static, dynamic and guided schedules	bit-identical
Known-value tests (all padding modes, 2×2 convolution sums, pooling)	pass
Global average pooling across thread counts	within 10^{-3} (summation order; documented)
ThreadSanitizer with Archer (OpenMP-aware race detector)	**no data races**
AddressSanitizer + UndefinedBehaviorSanitizer	clean
Independent NumPy implementation: padding, convolution, max pooling	**0** grey-level difference
Average pooling vs NumPy	±1 grey level (float32 vs float64 rounding)

The C test suite (27 tests, 41,119 assertions) runs on Linux, macOS and Windows on every push, and can be run from the GUI's Test-suite tab with one click.



7. Conclusions

1. **Arithmetic intensity predicts scaling.** Convolution, with many operations per byte, scales ideally; padding and pooling are limited by memory.
2. **The right decomposition removes synchronisation.** Giving each thread whole output rows made atomics and locks unnecessary.
3. **Algorithm details matter for both speed and correctness.** Clamped pooling windows are faster *and* avoid a real correctness bug that padded copies would cause.
4. **Parallel code must be tested for exact equality.** Bit-identical output across thread counts and schedules is the practical proof that there is no data race.